



NAIDU'S VOWS

- All crop loans will be waived. In fact, he suggests that the farmers stop making repayments immediately.
- Nine hours of free uninterrupted electricity supply for farming and allied agricultural activities.
- A dole of Rs 1,000 a month for all jobless youth.
- Reservation for poor in educational institutions and government jobs.
- Four per cent reservation for Muslims in educational institutions and government jobs.
- Special panchayat status for all tribal habitations, which will entitle them for development funds.
- Free piped gas from the Krishna-Godavari basin to all poor and middle-class families in the state.
- hike in old age and widow pensions to Rs 500 a month.

he says in writing on key issues of public importance or he has to admit that his government's policies were wrong."

No less distressing are the pulls and pressures within the TDP, with a sizeable group from the Telangana region opposing Naidu's ambivalent stand on a separate state. Though he had earlier announced that he would collect the views of the people during his tour, he has remained silent on the issue so far. Worse still, he has chosen to align with CPI(M), which is unequivocally against the division of Andhra Pradesh. Compounding his problems is the undefined challenge posed by the imminent emergence of a party to be floated by actor Chiranjeevi later this year. Forecasts about the actor's bright electoral prospects have prompted some to desert TDP. They include Jyotula Nehru, the influential president of the East

NEW LEAF: Naidu wooing villagers

Godavari district of TDP, which implies major erosion in the party's support base among OBCs in the area. The new party is likely to hit TDP the hardest.

The mounting pressures and grim prospects of TDP in a now-or-never electoral battle have also forced Naidu to turn for support to the NTR family in furthering his ambition. He got his only child, Lokesh, studying business management course in the US, to marry his first cousin, Brahmani, the elder daughter of his wife's brother and NTR's actor son Balakrishna last year. And for the only seat that his party could get in the biennial Rajya Sabha polls earlier this year, he picked up NTR's another actor son, the mercurial Harikrishna, overlooking the claims of several seasoned partymen. Harikrishna has made his presence felt in TDP politics occupying

the driver's seat in the legendary Chaitanya Ratham of NTR during several phases of electioneering, then floating a breakaway TDP to take on Naidu and finally, returning, to drive Naidu around for a few short spells on his current journey through the state. But Naidu is suspect in the eyes of sister-in-law and Union Minister of State for Human Resources Development D. Purandareswari. "He is a jackal of all seasons as the past master of the use and throw art. He will dump anyone immediately after the danger he is facing, passes. He cannot be trusted," she warns. An unfazed Naidu though is relying on umpteen promises made in the countryside and unbridled criticism of the Congress to uproot Reddy and grab the coveted chair in less than a year. At the moment, that seems like a tall order. ■